

BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT · SALES

Sales & Business Development — Fundamentals

From first principles: what selling really is, the roles ladder, funnels & pipelines, the sales cycle, GTM, and how to read a sales offer in India.

A beginner's field manual · Indian & fintech context · INR throughout · Guide 01 of the BD learning series

Contents

1. Why this guide exists — and the mindset shift for an analyst
2. What sales and business development actually are
3. Sales vs Business Development vs Marketing vs Account Management
4. The sales roles ladder: who does what, all day
5. Fresher entry points in India
6. B2B vs B2C vs B2B2C selling
7. Selling styles: transactional, consultative, solution, value
8. Inbound vs Outbound
9. The buyer's journey: awareness → consideration → decision
10. The sales funnel and pipeline (why pipeline > funnel)
11. The end-to-end sales cycle: the map
12. Core mindset & skills
13. Go-to-market (GTM) basics
14. Sales–marketing alignment
15. Compensation: base, variable, OTE, quota, accelerators
16. How a fresher reads an Indian sales offer
17. A day and a week in the life of an SDR/BDE
18. Q&A bank (40 questions)
19. Glossary of every acronym

1. Why this guide exists — and the mindset shift for an analyst

You come from a world where the answer is either right or wrong. On an F&O (Futures & Options) desk, a mispriced spread is a fact; a Greek is a number; a hedge either neutralises delta or it does not. Sales is not that world. In sales the "answer" is a **human decision made under uncertainty, with a budget, a boss, a deadline, and a fear of looking stupid**. Your job is not to be right — it is to help another person become confident enough to say yes and to sign.

This is good news for you. The skills that made you effective at D.E. Shaw — structured thinking, comfort with numbers, pattern recognition, discipline, and the habit of quantifying everything — are exactly what average salespeople lack. Most salespeople cannot do funnel math, cannot reason about conversion rates, and cannot forecast a pipeline honestly. You can. What you are missing is the **human layer**: listening more than you talk, sitting comfortably in someone else's problem, and building trust before you build a case. This guide teaches the vocabulary, the map, and the mindset. Later guides go deep on each stage.

One honest warning up front: sales rewards **consistency over cleverness**. A brilliant pitch delivered once loses to an average pitch delivered 100 times with follow-up. Treat sales like a trading system — a repeatable process with a measurable edge, run every day whether you feel like it or not. That framing will carry you further than charisma.

Key takeaways: Sales is helping a human decide under uncertainty, not proving you are right. Your analytical background is an unfair advantage on the numbers; your gap is the human layer — listening, empathy, trust. Win through disciplined, repeated process, not one-off brilliance.

2. What sales and business development actually are

2.1 Sales, defined plainly

Sales is the process of helping a specific person or organisation move from a problem they have to a solution you provide, and getting a commitment (usually money, a signature, or a purchase order) in return. Notice three words: *specific* (one named buyer, not a market), *problem* (you sell to a need, not a feature), and *commitment* (nothing counts until someone commits). Everything else — the calls, the demos, the emails — is just machinery to reach that commitment.

A cleaner way to hold it: **sales is the transfer of belief**. You believe your product solves the buyer's problem better than the alternatives (including doing nothing). The sale happens when that belief transfers into the buyer's head strongly enough to overcome their inertia and their fear. If you do not believe it, you cannot transfer it — which is why mis-selling both fails and is unethical.

2.2 Business development, defined plainly

Business development (BD) is the work of creating new avenues of growth — new customers, new markets, new partnerships, new channels — often *before* a repeatable sales process exists for them. Where a salesperson works an existing playbook to close known deals, a business developer is frequently **building the playbook**: figuring out who the customer is, whether they will pay, which partner can open a door, and how to package the offer.

In practice the words blur. In most Indian startups and mid-size companies, a "Business Development Executive" (BDE) or "Business Development Representative" (BDR) is doing front-line sales — prospecting and closing. In large or strategic contexts, "BD" means partnerships and market entry: signing a distribution deal, integrating with a bank, entering a new city. Read the job description, not the title. Ask in the interview: "Is this role prospecting and closing individual customers, or is it building partnerships and channels?" The answer tells you what you will actually do.

Working definitions to memorise

Sales = converting a specific, identified prospect into a paying customer through a defined process.

Business development = creating and opening *new* paths to revenue (customers, segments, partners, channels), often before the process is defined.

where: in small Indian firms BD ≈ front-line sales; in large firms BD ≈ partnerships/market entry. Always confirm from the JD (Job Description).

2.3 The relationship between them

Think of a funnel factory. Business development decides *which* factories to build and *where* to build them (which markets, which partners feed us leads). Sales runs the factory line — turning raw leads into signed customers efficiently and repeatedly. Marketing builds demand so raw material keeps arriving. Account management and customer success keep the finished customers happy so they buy again. You will likely start on the sales line (as an SDR/BDR or BDE), and that is the right place to learn the craft.

Common trap: Treating "business development" as a fancier, less salesy word so you can avoid the discomfort of selling. In 90% of India fresher roles labelled "BD", you *will* prospect, cold-call, and chase closes. If the discomfort of asking for money bothers you, name it and train it — do not hide behind a title.

Key takeaways: Sales = convert an identified prospect via a defined process. BD = create new paths to revenue, often before the process exists. Titles blur in India — read the JD. You will start on the sales line; that is where the craft is learned.

3. Sales vs Business Development vs Marketing vs Account Management

These four functions form the revenue engine (often called "GTM" — go-to-market, defined in §13). Confusing them is the single most common beginner mistake and a fast way to fail an interview. Here is the crisp comparison.

Dimension	Marketing	Business Development	Sales	Account Mgmt / CS
Core question	How do many people learn we exist and want us?	What new markets/partners/channels should we open?	Will <i>this named</i> prospect buy, and how do I close them?	Will this existing customer stay, renew, and buy more?
Audience	One-to-many (segments, markets)	Strategic few (partners, key logos, segments)	One-to-one (individual prospects)	One-to-one (existing customers)
Owns	Awareness, demand, brand, leads (MQLs)	Pipeline of new opportunities/partnerships	Closing revenue (new bookings)	Retention, renewals, upsell, NPS
Time horizon	Weeks to quarters	Months to years	Days to a few months	Ongoing (the whole lifetime)
Key metric	Leads, CAC, MQLs, pipeline sourced	Partnerships signed, new-market revenue	Bookings, win rate, quota attainment	Net revenue retention, churn, upsell
Typical output	Ads, content, events, SEO, emails	Deals, alliances, market-entry plans	Signed contracts / paid orders	Renewed contracts, expansions

Read the table as a hand-off chain: **Marketing → BD → Sales → Account Management**. Marketing generates interest at scale and passes qualified leads down. BD opens strategic doors and hands warm opportunities across. Sales converts individuals into signed customers. Account management/customer success (CS) then protects and grows that revenue. Money is easiest to earn from customers you already have, which is why retention is treated as its own discipline.

Worked scenario — one fintech, four functions

A fintech sells an automated GST-reconciliation SaaS (Software-as-a-Service) to Indian SMEs (Small and Medium Enterprises). Watch each function touch the same goal from a different angle:

- **Marketing** runs a LinkedIn campaign and a webinar "Cut GST filing time by 70%", capturing 400 sign-ups (leads).
- **BD** signs a partnership with a chain of Chartered Accountant (CA) firms so those CAs recommend the tool to their clients — a whole new channel of demand.
- **Sales** (an Account Executive) takes the 40 webinar sign-ups who requested a demo, runs discovery calls, handles the "is our data safe?" objection, and closes 8 of them on ₹60,000/year plans.
- **Account management / CS** onboards those 8, ensures they actually file through the tool, and 11 months later upsells 3 of them to a ₹1.8 lakh multi-entity plan and renews the rest.

Same product, one revenue engine, four jobs. In a 20-person startup, one or two people may wear all four hats — but the *functions* are still distinct, and good operators know which hat they have on at any moment.

Common trap: In interviews, saying "sales and marketing are basically the same." They are not. Marketing is one-to-many demand creation; sales is one-to-one demand capture and conversion. If you blur them, you signal you have never done either. State the hand-off chain instead.

Key takeaways: Marketing (one-to-many, awareness/leads) → BD (strategic doors/partnerships) → Sales (one-to-one closing) → Account Management/CS (retention & upsell). Each owns a different metric. Retention is a discipline of its own because existing customers are the cheapest revenue.

4. The sales roles ladder: who does what, all day

Sales is a team sport with specialised positions, like a football side. Understanding the ladder tells you where you enter, what "good" looks like at each rung, and where you are heading. The two front-line roles you will hear most are **SDR/BDR** and **AE/BDE**. Learn these cold.

4.1 SDR / BDR — the prospector (usual fresher entry)

SDR = Sales Development Representative. BDR = Business Development Representative. Same job, different label (SDR often means they qualify *inbound* leads that marketing generated; BDR often means they generate *outbound* leads by cold prospecting — but companies use the terms interchangeably). This is the classic entry point.

Their one job: create qualified sales opportunities and hand them to a closer. They do not close deals. They open them. Day-to-day: building lists of target companies, finding the right contact, sending cold emails and LinkedIn messages, making cold calls, following up relentlessly, and booking qualified meetings for an Account Executive. Success is measured in **activity** (calls/emails sent) and **output** (qualified meetings booked, opportunities created). A typical target might be "20 qualified meetings booked per month."

4.2 AE / BDE — the closer

AE = Account Executive. In India the same closing role is often titled **BDE = Business Development Executive** or "Sales Executive." **Their one job:** take qualified opportunities and turn them into signed, paying customers. Day-to-day: running discovery calls, giving demos/presentations, writing proposals, negotiating pricing, handling objections, and getting the contract signed. Success is measured by **quota attainment** — the revenue they close against a target (e.g., ₹40 lakh of new bookings per quarter). This is where the money is, because closers carry a number.

4.3 Account Manager (AM) & Customer Success Manager (CSM) — the keeper

Once a customer is signed, they hand off (or the AE keeps them, in small firms) to an **Account Manager** or **Customer Success Manager (CSM)**. **Their one job:** make the customer successful so they renew and buy more. AM leans commercial (renewals, upsell, cross-sell); CSM leans toward adoption and outcomes (onboarding, training, health monitoring). Metric: **Net Revenue Retention (NRR)** — did the account's spend grow, stay, or shrink? — plus churn and NPS (Net Promoter Score, a loyalty measure).

4.4 Key Account Manager (KAM) — the strategic keeper

A **Key Account Manager** owns the handful of largest, most strategic customers (the "whales" — think a KAM at a fintech owning the HDFC or Razorpay relationship). These accounts are too important for a normal AM. The KAM builds deep, multi-threaded relationships (many contacts across the client), forecasts and grows a large book, and coordinates internal teams to serve the account. High trust, long cycles, big numbers.

4.5 Sales Manager — the coach

A **Sales Manager** leads a team of SDRs or AEs. **Their one job:** hit the team's aggregate number by hiring, coaching, forecasting, and removing blockers. They do not (usually) carry personal deals; they carry the *team* quota. They run the pipeline reviews, the 1:1s, and the forecast calls. This is the first management rung and a common 3–5 year goal for a strong AE.

4.6 RevOps — the engine room

RevOps = Revenue Operations. The team that builds and maintains the systems the whole engine runs on: the CRM (Customer Relationship Management system, e.g., Salesforce, HubSpot, Zoho), the data, the reporting, the forecasting models, the commission calculations, and the process design. If sales is the trading desk, RevOps is the desk's technology-and-risk infrastructure. **This is a role your CS + analytics + F&O background maps onto beautifully** — keep it in mind as a possible non-obvious entry or a fast pivot after a year on the front line.

Role	Full name	One-line job	Primary metric	Carries a quota?
SDR/BDR	Sales/Business Dev Representative	Create qualified opportunities	Meetings / opps booked	Activity-based target
AE/BDE	Account Exec / Biz Dev Exec	Close deals into paying customers	Bookings / win rate	Yes — revenue quota
AM	Account Manager	Renew & grow existing accounts	Net revenue retention	Yes — retention/upsell
CSM	Customer Success Manager	Drive adoption & outcomes	Churn, NPS, adoption	Sometimes (soft)
KAM	Key Account Manager	Own the strategic whales	Account growth	Yes — large book
Sales Manager	—	Lead & coach a sales team	Team quota attainment	Yes — team number
RevOps	Revenue Operations	Build the systems & data	Process, forecast accuracy	No (enabling)

Key takeaways: SDR/BDR opens; AE/BDE closes; AM/CSM keeps & grows; KAM owns the whales; Sales Manager coaches the team; RevOps builds the machine. Freshers almost always start SDR/BDR or BDE. RevOps is a hidden fit for your analytical/CS profile.

5. Fresher entry points in India

For an MBA-Finance fresher with a CS background and market experience, here are the realistic doors, roughly from easiest-to-enter to most-aligned-with-your-strengths:

- **SDR / BDR at a B2B SaaS or fintech** (Bengaluru, Gurugram, Pune, Mumbai, Hyderabad). Highest volume of openings. Titles: "Sales Development Representative", "Inside Sales Executive", "Business Development Representative". Expect heavy calling/emailing. Best pure training ground for the craft.
- **BDE / Inside Sales Executive at an edtech, fintech, or SaaS** — a closing role with lower ticket sizes. You will both prospect and close. High activity, fast feedback.
- **Relationship Manager (RM) / Sales in BFSI** (Banking, Financial Services, Insurance) — banks, broking firms, wealth/AMC, insurance. Your NISM Series-XV (a SEBI-regulated certification for social/ESG or for the relevant securities-market module) and F&O background are directly credible here. Selling demat accounts, broking, mutual funds, PMS, insurance.
- **Pre-Sales / Sales Engineer** at a fintech or enterprise-SaaS — the technical partner to the AE who runs demos and handles the "how does it actually work" questions. Your CS background shines; less cold-calling.
- **RevOps / Sales Analyst / Sales Strategy** — analytical roles supporting the sales team with data, dashboards, and forecasting. A strong non-obvious fit; sometimes reachable directly, often after a year on the floor.

My honest recommendation: for the first job, prioritise learning the craft over the title. An SDR/BDR seat at a well-run B2B company with a real sales process (a manager who coaches, a CRM, a defined motion) will teach you more in 12 months than a fancy title at a chaotic firm. Optimise for **process quality and coaching**, then for base pay.

Key takeaways: Your realistic doors: SDR/BDR at SaaS/fintech, BDE/inside sales, RM in BFSI (where your NISM + markets background is directly credible), pre-sales/sales engineer (CS shines), or RevOps/sales analyst. First job: optimise for process quality and coaching over title.

6. B2B vs B2C vs B2B2C selling

Who your buyer is changes everything — the cycle length, the number of decision-makers, the ticket size, and the emotional vs rational balance of the sale.

Dimension	B2B (Business-to-Business)	B2C (Business-to-Consumer)	B2B2C (via a partner to end-consumer)
Buyer	An organisation (multiple people)	An individual person	You sell to a business that reaches the consumer
Decision-makers	Many (a "buying committee")	One (maybe a spouse)	Partner decides; end-user experiences
Ticket size	High (₹lakhs to ₹crores)	Low (₹ hundreds to lakhs)	Mixed
Sales cycle	Weeks to many months	Minutes to days	Long to sign partner, then scaled
Driver	ROI, risk, business case (mostly rational)	Emotion, convenience, price, brand	Partner economics + end-user value
Fintech example	Selling a payments API to a company's finance team	A consumer downloading a UPI/investing app	A lender embedding "Buy Now Pay Later" inside a retailer's checkout

You are pivoting primarily toward **B2B** (and BFSI relationship sales, which is B2C-ish but high-consideration). B2B suits your temperament: it rewards preparation, rational business cases, and patient multi-step process over on-the-spot charm. The core B2B truth to internalise: **you are rarely selling to one person — you are selling to a committee**, each with different motivations (the user wants ease, the finance head wants ROI, the IT head wants security, the CXO wants strategic outcome). Great B2B sellers map and serve the whole committee.

Common trap: Selling B2B as if it were B2C — pitching one enthusiastic user and assuming the deal is done. Then a finance controller or an IT security head you never spoke to kills it. In B2B, always ask: "Who else needs to be comfortable for this to go ahead?"

Key takeaways: B2B = sell to an organisation and its buying committee; long cycle, high ticket, rational ROI/risk. B2C = sell to one person; fast, emotional. B2B2C = sell through a partner to reach consumers. B2B fits your analytical temperament — but never forget the committee.

7. Selling styles: transactional, consultative, solution, value

"Selling" is not one thing. The right style depends on price, complexity, and how much the buyer needs help thinking. These four form a spectrum from "just take the order" to "reframe the customer's whole business case."

Style	What it is	Best when	Fintech example
Transactional	Fast, price/convenience-led; little advising. Take the order efficiently.	Simple, cheap, low-risk, buyer already knows what they want	Selling a ₹499/month personal-finance app
Consultative	Ask deep questions, diagnose the real need, recommend a fit. You act like an advisor.	Medium complexity; buyer unsure of the best answer	Advising an SME on which invoicing + GST plan fits their workflow
Solution	Assemble multiple products/services into a tailored answer to a defined business problem.	Complex needs, several moving parts	Bundling payments + lending + reconciliation for a marketplace
Value	Quantify business impact in the buyer's terms (₹ saved/earned, risk reduced); sell the outcome and ROI, not features.	High ticket, ROI-driven buyers, competitive deals	"Our fraud engine cuts ₹2.4 crore of annual chargebacks — here's the model"

These are not rigid boxes; a good B2B seller blends them, usually running **consultative discovery** then presenting a **value-based** business case. The common thread from consultative onward is the same discipline: **diagnose before you prescribe**. A doctor who prescribes before examining is committing malpractice; so is a salesperson who pitches before discovering.

Key takeaways: Transactional (fast, price-led) → Consultative (diagnose & advise) → Solution (assemble a tailored answer) → Value (quantify the ₹ outcome). For your B2B/fintech path, master consultative discovery + value framing. Always diagnose before you prescribe.

8. Inbound vs Outbound

This describes *how the conversation starts* — who reached out first.

- **Inbound:** the prospect comes to you (downloaded a whitepaper, filled a "Contact Sales" form, attended a webinar, searched and found you). They already have some awareness and intent. Warmer, but you still qualify hard — many inbound leads are students, competitors, or tyre-kickers.
- **Outbound:** you reach out first to someone who has not asked to hear from you (cold call, cold email, LinkedIn message). Colder, harder, higher rejection — but you choose exactly whom to target, so you can go after your ideal customers directly instead of waiting.

An SDR handling inbound spends the day qualifying and routing warm leads; a BDR doing outbound spends the day researching targets and initiating cold contact. Most strong pipelines use both. Outbound is the harder skill and the one that makes you truly valuable, because a seller who can *manufacture* pipeline from nothing is never out of work.

Key takeaways: Inbound = prospect contacts you (warmer, still qualify). Outbound = you contact them cold (harder, but you pick the targets). Both matter; mastering outbound makes you durably employable because you can create pipeline on demand.

9. The buyer's journey: awareness → consideration → decision

Before we map *your* process, understand the **buyer's** process — because good selling mirrors how people actually buy, rather than pushing them along the seller's convenience. The buyer's journey has three classic stages.

Stage	Buyer's mental state	What the buyer wants	What good selling does here
1. Awareness	"I have a problem / an itch, but I haven't defined it."	To understand and name their problem	Educate; help them frame the problem (content, insight). Do NOT pitch product.
2. Consideration	"I've named the problem; what are my options?"	To compare approaches & vendors	Discovery + tailored solution; show fit vs alternatives.
3. Decision	"I've shortlisted; can I justify and de-risk the choice?"	Proof, ROI, references, safety	Business case, proof (pilot/references), handle risk, close.

The single biggest beginner error is **talking about your product in the awareness stage**, when the buyer has not even agreed they have a problem worth solving. It is like proposing marriage on a first date. Match your message to where the buyer *actually is*. Remember too the invisible fourth option that beats everyone in early stages: **"do nothing / stick with the status quo."** Most B2B deals are lost not to a competitor but to inertia. Part of your job is making the cost of inaction visible.

Worked example — mapping a real fintech product to the buyer's journey

Product: an automated expense-management + corporate-card platform for Indian startups (think a Ramp/Volopay-style tool). **Buyer:** the Finance Head of a 120-person Series-B startup.

- **Awareness:** The Finance Head is drowning in month-end — chasing employees for reimbursement bills over WhatsApp, reconciling manually. They haven't thought "I need a platform," just "month-end is painful." **Right move:** a LinkedIn post / short guide: "Why month-end takes finance teams 6 days — and the 3 hidden costs." You are naming their pain, not pitching.
- **Consideration:** Now they're Googling "expense management software India" and comparing you vs Zoho Expense vs spreadsheets-plus-cards. **Right move:** a discovery call to understand their exact workflow, then a demo showing how your tool fits *their* reimbursement flow — and honestly where a competitor differs.
- **Decision:** They've shortlisted you and one rival. The CFO wants justification; IT wants security proof. **Right move:** an ROI model ("saves 4 finance-hours/day = ₹X/year; cuts reimbursement cycle from 8 days to 1"), a 2-week pilot on one department, a reference call with a similar startup, and SOC-2/security docs for IT. Then ask for the signature.

Notice how the *same* product is sold three completely different ways depending on the buyer's stage. That is the whole art of stage-matching.

Common trap: Pitching product features to an awareness-stage buyer. They haven't accepted they have a problem worth money, so features sound like noise and you get "we'll think about it." Educate first; pitch only when they've entered consideration.

Key takeaways: Buyers move awareness → consideration → decision. Educate in awareness, diagnose & show fit in consideration, prove & de-risk in decision. Your biggest rival is "do nothing" — make the cost of inaction visible. Match your message to where the buyer actually is.

10. The sales funnel and pipeline (why pipeline > funnel)

10.1 The funnel: stages and shrinkage

The **sales funnel** is a model of how a large number of raw leads shrinks, stage by stage, into a small number of paying customers. It is a funnel because most people drop out at each step. The canonical B2B stages:

Stage	Meaning	Who owns it
Lead	Any contact who might conceivably buy (a name + email)	Marketing / SDR
MQL (Marketing Qualified Lead)	Showed enough interest/fit that marketing judges them worth sales' time	Marketing
SQL (Sales Qualified Lead)	Sales has verified real need, fit, and intent — worth pursuing	SDR → AE
Opportunity	A qualified deal actively being worked (discovery done, real chance)	AE
Proposal / Negotiation	Formal quote/contract on the table; terms being agreed	AE
Closed Won / Closed Lost	Signed & paying (won) — or dead (lost)	AE

The **conversion rate** between two stages is simply: how many advanced ÷ how many entered. Multiply the stage rates together and you get your end-to-end conversion. This is where your quant brain gives you an edge over 90% of salespeople who never do this math.

Funnel / conversion math

Stage conversion = (deals reaching next stage) ÷ (deals entering this stage)

Deals needed at top = Target closed-won ÷ (product of all stage conversions)

Required activity = Deals needed at top ÷ (top-of-funnel conversion per unit of activity)

where: "activity" = calls/emails/outreach. Reason backwards from the revenue target to the daily activity — exactly like sizing positions backwards from a risk limit.

Worked example — funnel math for a fintech SaaS BDE

Goal: close 4 new customers this month. Average deal = ₹1,00,000/year, so that's ₹4,00,000 of new bookings. Historical stage conversions:

- Cold outreach → reply (positive): 8%
- Positive reply → discovery meeting held (SQL): 50%
- Discovery → opportunity (demo + real fit): 60%
- Opportunity → proposal sent: 70%
- Proposal → closed won: 40%

Work backwards from 4 wins:

- Proposals needed = $4 \div 0.40 = 10$ proposals
- Opportunities needed = $10 \div 0.70 = \approx 15$ opportunities
- Discovery meetings needed = $15 \div 0.60 = 25$ meetings
- Positive replies needed = $25 \div 0.50 = 50$ positive replies
- Cold outreaches needed = $50 \div 0.08 = \approx 625$ outreaches this month

That's roughly **$625 \div 22$ working days ≈ 28 quality outreaches per day** to hit 4 wins. Now the target is not a vague hope — it's a daily activity number you can execute and track, exactly like a systematic trader executing a fixed number of signals. If wins fall short, you diagnose *which stage conversion* broke and fix that specific leak, rather than panicking.

10.2 Funnel vs pipeline — the crucial distinction

People use "funnel" and "pipeline" loosely, but the distinction matters and shows up in interviews.

- The **funnel** is a *model/aggregate*: percentages and volumes describing how leads convert on average. It answers "how does our conversion look overall?"
- The **pipeline** is the *live list of real, named deals* you are working right now, each at a specific stage, with an expected value and close date. It answers "which specific deals do I have, worth how much, likely to close when?"

Why pipeline > funnel for a working seller: the funnel is a rear-view mirror (averages from the past); the pipeline is your live book of positions. You manage a pipeline the way you'd manage open trades — each deal has a size (deal value), a probability (stage), and an expected close date. Weighted pipeline = Σ (deal value $\times$ stage probability) gives a forecast. You cannot close a "funnel"; you close named deals in a pipeline. Diligent **pipeline hygiene** — updating each deal's stage, next step, and close date honestly in the CRM — is what separates professionals from amateurs and is the difference between a forecast you can trust and one you can't.

Weighted pipeline (simple forecast)

Weighted pipeline value = Σ (deal value $\times$ probability at its current stage)

Coverage ratio = Total open pipeline value $\div$ Quota

where: a healthy coverage ratio is often 3 $\times$ –4 $\times$ quota (you need ~ 3 –4 rupees of pipeline for every rupee of target, because most deals slip or die). Low coverage today = a missed quota next quarter — a leading indicator, like open interest signalling future flow.

Common trap: Poor pipeline hygiene — leaving dead deals marked "open," inflating close dates, or not logging next steps. It feels harmless but it destroys forecast accuracy, hides which stage is actually leaking,

and gets managers fired. Update every deal after every interaction. An honest small pipeline beats a fantasy large one.

Key takeaways: Funnel = the model of average conversion (rear-view). Pipeline = your live, named deals with value, stage-probability, and close date (your open book). Do funnel math backwards from the revenue target to a daily activity number. Manage the pipeline like open trades; obsessive hygiene is non-negotiable. Coverage of $\sim 3-4\times$ quota is healthy.

11. The end-to-end sales cycle: the map

The **sales cycle** is the sequence of steps to take one deal from "never heard of us" to "happy, expanding customer." This guide gives you the map; later guides in the series go deep on each stage (prospecting, discovery, demos, objection handling, negotiation, closing). Memorise the eight stages and what "done" looks like at each.

#	Stage	Goal	"Done" looks like
1	Prospect	Find and reach the right potential buyers	Right person engaged in a conversation
2	Qualify	Confirm there's real need, fit, budget, authority, timing	Verified this is a worth-pursuing SQL (or disqualified fast)
3	Discover	Deeply understand their problem, impact, and decision process	You can state their problem better than they can
4	Present / Demo	Show how you solve <i>their specific</i> problem	Buyer sees a credible, tailored path to their outcome
5	Handle objections	Surface and resolve real concerns (price, risk, timing)	Concerns addressed honestly; buyer still moving
6	Close	Ask for and secure the commitment	Signed contract / paid order
7	Onboard	Deliver the promised value quickly (first value fast)	Customer live and getting the outcome
8	Expand	Renew, upsell, cross-sell, get referrals	Account grows & advocates for you

Two truths to carry: (1) **Qualification is where discipline pays.** The most valuable skill of a good seller is *disqualifying fast* — killing deals that will never close so you spend time on deals that will. Chasing bad-fit deals is the sales equivalent of averaging down on a losing position. (2) **The sale doesn't end at "closed won."** Onboarding and expansion are where the real money and the referrals live; a signature is the start of the relationship, not the finish line.

A useful qualification checklist you'll hear constantly is **BANT — Budget, Authority, Need, Timing**: Does the prospect have money? Are you talking to (or can you reach) the decision-maker? Is there a real, painful need? Is there a timeframe to act? Newer frameworks like MEDDIC exist too, but BANT is the beginner's workhorse.

Key takeaways: Eight stages: Prospect → Qualify → Discover → Present → Handle objections → Close → Onboard → Expand. Disqualifying fast is a superpower — don't average down on bad deals. "Closed won" is the start, not the end; onboarding + expansion is where compounding revenue lives. Qualify with BANT (Budget, Authority, Need, Timing).

12. Core mindset & skills

Frameworks are the easy part; the human skills are what actually move deals. Here are the core ones, framed for an analytical beginner.

12.1 Active listening (the #1 skill)

The best salespeople listen far more than they talk — a common benchmark is the buyer talking ~60–70% of the time on a discovery call. **Active listening** means: fully attending, not planning your next line while they speak; reflecting back what you heard ("So if I understand right, the real pain is the 6-day close, not the software cost itself?"); and asking a follow-up that goes deeper. For you, the retrain is specific: your instinct as a smart analyst is to jump to the answer. Suppress it. The person who asks the best questions — not the one with the best answers — controls the sale.

12.2 Empathy

Empathy is genuinely feeling the buyer's situation — their pressure, their risk of looking bad if the purchase fails, their boss breathing down their neck. Buyers buy from people who clearly *get* them. This is not manipulation; it's the foundation of trust. A buyer's biggest hidden fear in B2B is career risk — "if this fails, I own the mistake." De-risking that fear is often the real sale.

12.3 Discovery questioning

The skill of asking open, layered questions that uncover the real problem, its business impact, and the decision process. Open questions start with what/how/why/tell-me-about and cannot be answered with yes/no. Great discovery digs from surface pain → business impact → cost of inaction. (A full guide covers frameworks like SPIN — Situation, Problem, Implication, Need-payoff.)

Worked example — a discovery-question set (fintech expense tool)

A reusable ladder you could run on that Finance Head, moving from surface to depth:

1. **Situation:** "Walk me through how expense reimbursements work today, from an employee spending to it hitting your books."
2. **Problem:** "Where does that process break down or eat the most time?"
3. **Quantify:** "Roughly how many hours a month does your team spend chasing bills and reconciling? How many people?"
4. **Impact:** "What does that delay cost you — in overtime, in month-end slipping, in errors?"
5. **Cost of inaction:** "If nothing changes over the next year as you scale to 200 people, what happens?"
6. **Decision process:** "If you found the right tool, who else would need to sign off — finance, IT, the CFO? What's your process for a purchase like this?"
7. **Success criteria:** "If we spoke a year from now and this was a great decision, what would be true?"

Notice: not one word about your product yet. By the end you know the pain, its rupee cost, the buying committee, and what "success" means — everything you need to build a value case. **That** is discovery.

12.4 Storytelling

Humans decide with emotion and justify with logic. A **story** — "a startup exactly your size was losing 6 days every month-end; 90 days after switching, their close takes 1 day and the finance head got promoted" — lands harder than a feature list, because the buyer sees themselves in it. Learn to tell crisp customer stories: situation → struggle → change → result.

12.5 Resilience & consistency

Sales is a game of rejection. A 5–10% positive reply rate on cold outreach means **you are told "no" (or ignored) ~90% of the time** — and that's normal, not failure. Resilience is not taking it personally; consistency is doing the activity every day regardless of mood. Reframe rejection as data: each "no" is one step through a known conversion rate toward the next "yes." That's a framing your trading background makes natural — you don't rage at a losing trade in a positive-expectancy system; you take the next signal.

12.6 Time management

Your scarcest asset is selling time. Winners protect blocks for prospecting, batch admin, and — crucially — spend time on the *right* deals (which loops back to disqualifying fast). A common rule: spend the first 1–2 hours of the day on prospecting before the reactive noise starts.

12.7 Ethics — no mis-selling

Never sell someone something that won't help them, hide a material limitation, or over-promise to close. Mis-selling wins one deal and loses the customer, the referrals, and the renewal — and in Indian BFSI it can breach SEBI/IRDAI/RBI regulations and end your career. Ethical selling is also the higher-EV strategy: trust compounds, reputation is your real book, and referrals are the cheapest pipeline you'll ever get. Sell only what you'd buy in the customer's shoes.

Common trap: Talking to fill silence. Beginners fear pauses and rush to pitch, burying the buyer's own words. Ask a question, then *be quiet* and let them talk — even through an awkward silence. The silence does the selling.

Key takeaways: Listen ~60–70% of the time; the best questioner controls the sale. Empathy de-risks the buyer's career fear. Discovery digs surface pain → rupee impact → cost of inaction. Stories beat feature lists. Treat rejection as expected data, act consistently, protect selling time, disqualify fast, and never mis-sell — trust is your real book.

13. Go-to-market (GTM) basics

Go-to-market (GTM) is the overall plan for *how* a company brings a product to customers and wins: who we sell to, what we say, and how we reach and close them. As a seller you execute the GTM; understanding it makes you far more than an order-taker. Its building blocks:

13.1 ICP — Ideal Customer Profile

The **ICP** is a precise description of the customer you serve best — the ones who get the most value, close fastest, and stay longest. For a fintech, an ICP might be: "Indian D2C (direct-to-consumer) brands, ₹5–50 crore revenue, 50–300 employees, already selling online, using Razorpay/Shopify." The ICP is your targeting filter. Selling *outside* ICP is the most common way sellers waste months on deals that were never going to work. Know your ICP cold and disqualify anything far outside it.

13.2 Value proposition

A **value proposition** is a crisp statement of the value you deliver: for [ICP], who [have this problem], we provide [this], which delivers [this quantified outcome], unlike [alternatives]. Example: "For growing Indian SMEs drowning in GST reconciliation, we automate matching so filing takes hours not days, cutting errors and penalties — unlike manual spreadsheets or generic accounting software." Not features — the *outcome* the buyer cares about.

13.3 Positioning

Positioning is the place your product occupies in the buyer's mind relative to alternatives — what category you're in and why you're the right choice within it. ("We're the security-first payments API for regulated fintechs," vs "the cheapest payment gateway.") Positioning frames how the whole conversation is judged.

13.4 Channels

Channels are the routes to reach and sell to customers: direct sales (your own reps), digital/self-serve (they sign up on the website), partners/resellers, marketplaces, events. A company chooses channels that fit its price and complexity.

13.5 Sales motion — self-serve vs inside vs field

The **sales motion** is the dominant way deals actually get done, driven mainly by deal size (ACV — Annual Contract Value):

Motion	How it works	Typical deal size	Fintech example
Self-serve / PLG (Product-Led Growth)	Customer signs up & pays online with little/no human help; the product sells itself	Low (₹ hundreds–thousands/mo)	A developer signing up for a payments API sandbox and going live alone
Inside sales	Reps sell remotely by phone/video/email; no travel	Mid (₹ lakhs/yr)	An inside AE closing SMEs on a ₹1–5 lakh/yr plan over Zoom
Field sales	Reps meet buyers in person; long, high-touch, strategic	High (₹ tens of lakhs–crores)	An enterprise rep selling a payments platform to a large bank over 9 months

Most fresher roles are **inside sales** (or SDR feeding inside/field AEs) — remote, high-volume, fast feedback. That's the ideal training ground.

Key takeaways: GTM = the plan for who we sell to, what we say, and how we reach & close them. Core pieces: ICP (who you serve best — your targeting filter), value proposition (the quantified outcome), positioning (place in the buyer's mind), channels (routes), and sales motion (self-serve/PLG → inside → field, scaling with deal size). Freshers usually enter inside sales/SDR.

14. Sales–marketing alignment

Sales and marketing succeed or fail together, yet they famously fight — marketing says "sales wastes our leads," sales says "marketing sends garbage leads." **Alignment** is fixing this so the hand-off works. The mechanisms you should be able to name:

- **Shared ICP & definitions:** both teams agree what a "good lead," an MQL, and an SQL actually mean, so nothing falls through the cracks.
- **An SLA (Service Level Agreement):** a mutual promise — e.g., marketing delivers X qualified leads/month; sales follows up every lead within Y hours. Speed-to-lead is huge: contacting an inbound lead in 5 minutes vs 30 minutes can multiply conversion.
- **Closed-loop feedback:** sales tells marketing which leads converted and which were junk, so marketing targets better. This loop is where your analytical instinct adds real value.
- **Sometimes a "smarketing" or revenue team** under one leader (often a CRO — Chief Revenue Officer) owning the whole funnel end to end.

Common trap: As a new seller, blaming marketing for "bad leads" instead of working every lead fast and feeding back *specifically* why a lead didn't fit. The professionals close the loop with data; the amateurs just complain. Fast, specific feedback makes the next batch better and makes you look sharp.

Key takeaways: Alignment needs shared ICP + agreed MQL/SQL definitions, an SLA (lead volume + fast follow-up), and closed-loop feedback. Speed-to-lead massively affects conversion. Feed marketing specific data, don't just complain — it's where your analytics edge shows.

15. Compensation: base, variable, OTE, quota, accelerators

Sales pay is deliberately built to reward results — so you must read an offer differently from a fixed-salary job. Learn this vocabulary precisely; it directly affects your money.

Term	Meaning
Base salary (fixed)	The guaranteed part, paid regardless of performance. Your safety floor.
Variable / Commission / Incentive	The performance part — earned by hitting targets (booking revenue, meetings, etc.). Not guaranteed.
OTE (On-Target Earnings)	Base + variable <i>if you hit 100% of target</i> . The headline "expected" total. Realise it's a target, not a guarantee.
Quota	The target you must hit to earn full variable (e.g., ₹40 lakh bookings/quarter, or 20 meetings/month for an SDR).
Pay mix	The base : variable split. E.g., 70:30 (safer, common for SDRs) vs 50:50 (more upside/risk, common for closers).
Accelerators	Higher commission rate <i>above</i> 100% of quota — e.g., 1.5×–2× on every rupee past target. This is where top reps get rich.
Decelerators / cliffs	Below a threshold you may earn little/no commission (a "cliff"); some plans cap upside (avoid caps if you can).
Draw	A guaranteed minimum commission for the first few months while you ramp (sometimes "recoverable" — repaid from later commissions).
Clawback	Commission taken back if a customer churns/refunds soon after (common in BFSI).

How OTE works

OTE = Base + On-target Variable

Actual pay $\approx$ Base + (Variable $\times$ quota attainment %) [+ accelerators above 100%]

Example: Base ₹6L + On-target Variable ₹4L $\Rightarrow$ OTE ₹10L. At 80% attainment $\approx$ ₹6L + (₹4L $\times$ 0.8) = ₹9.2L.

At 130% with a 1.5× accelerator on the extra 30% $\approx$ ₹6L + ₹4L + (₹4L $\times$ 0.30 $\times$ 1.5) = ₹11.8L.

where: attainment % is your performance vs quota. Read the accelerator and any cliff/cap carefully — they swing your real income more than the headline OTE.

Key takeaways: Base = guaranteed; Variable = earned by hitting quota; OTE = base + on-target variable (a target, not a promise). Pay mix (e.g. 70:30) shows risk. Accelerators reward over-performance; cliffs/caps/clawbacks limit it. Actual pay $\approx$ base + variable $\times$ attainment.

16. How a fresher reads an Indian sales offer

Indian offers wrap all this in **CTC (Cost To Company)** — the total annual cost the employer assigns to you, which mixes guaranteed and non-guaranteed money and can be made to look bigger than what actually lands in your account. Decode it methodically:

- **Split CTC into fixed vs variable.** A "₹8 LPA (lakh per annum)" offer might be ₹5.5L fixed + ₹2.5L variable. Only the fixed part is guaranteed. Always ask: "What is the fixed component, and what is variable/incentive?"
- **Understand the variable's trigger.** Is variable paid monthly, quarterly, annually? On what metric? Is there a cliff (earn nothing below, say, 60% of target)? A big variable behind a hard, ill-defined quota can be near-fictional.
- **Check the ramp/draw.** As a fresher you'll take months to produce. Is there a guaranteed draw or a ramp period where you're not expected to hit full quota? If not, budget on the *fixed* alone for the first two quarters.
- **Look past inflated components.** CTC often includes employer PF (Provident Fund), gratuity, "flexi benefits," insurance, and even a notional ESOP (Employee Stock Option Plan) value. These aren't monthly take-home. Compute your realistic monthly in-hand from the *fixed* figure minus deductions.
- **Judge whether the quota is achievable.** Ask: "What % of the team hit quota last year? What's average ramp time? What's the average deal size and cycle length?" If most reps miss quota, the OTE is marketing, not reality.
- **Weigh learning, not just money.** For your first sales job, a slightly lower fixed at a company with a strong sales process, a coaching manager, a real CRM, and a product people actually want beats a higher OTE at a churn-and-burn shop. Optimise the first 12–18 months for skill.

Worked example — decoding two fresher offers

Offer A: "₹9 LPA CTC" SDR at a fast-growing B2B SaaS. Breakdown: ₹6L fixed + ₹2L variable (paid quarterly on meetings booked, no cliff) + ₹1L notional benefits/PF. Coaching manager, defined process, 3-month ramp with soft targets.

Offer B: "₹12 LPA CTC" BDE at a fledgling firm. Breakdown: ₹5L fixed + ₹7L variable behind a hard revenue quota with a 60% cliff, no ramp, no CRM, no sales manager. Last year 2 of 9 reps hit quota.

Analysis: Offer B's headline is 33% higher, but its *guaranteed* money (₹5L) is lower than A's (₹6L), and its ₹7L variable sits behind a cliff most reps miss — so realistic total may be well under A's. Worse, B has no coaching or process, so you'll learn slowly and burn out. **For a first job, Offer A wins** on guaranteed pay, achievable variable, and — most important — skill-building. The headline CTC is the least informative number on the page.

Common trap: Comparing offers on headline CTC. CTC blends fixed, hard-to-earn variable, and notional benefits. Two "₹10 LPA" offers can mean ₹7L vs ₹4L of realistic take-home. Always decompose into fixed, variable-with-its-trigger, and benefits before comparing.

Key takeaways: CTC ≠ take-home. Split every Indian offer into fixed (guaranteed), variable (with its metric, frequency, and cliff), and notional benefits. Check ramp/draw, quota achievability (what % of the team hits it), and above all the quality of process and coaching. For job one, optimise skill and guaranteed pay over headline CTC.

17. A day and a week in the life of an SDR/BDE

To make it concrete, here's a realistic rhythm for an inside-sales SDR/BDE at an Indian B2B fintech. Notice how much is **disciplined, repeatable process** — this should feel comfortable to you.

17.1 A day

Time	Activity
9:00–9:30	Review CRM: today's follow-ups, replies overnight, meetings booked. Plan the day around the pipeline.
9:30–11:30	Power hour(s) — prospecting: cold calls + personalised emails/LinkedIn to target-list accounts. Highest-value work, done before the day gets noisy.
11:30–13:00	Discovery/qualification calls with warm leads; book demos for the AE. Log everything in CRM immediately.
13:00–14:00	Lunch / recharge.
14:00–16:00	Second outreach block + follow-ups on earlier conversations (most replies come from follow-up #3–5, not #1).
16:00–17:00	Research tomorrow's target accounts; personalise outreach; refine messaging on what's working.
17:00–18:00	CRM hygiene: update every deal's stage & next step; report daily activity numbers; quick sync with AE/manager.

17.2 A week

- **Monday:** Pipeline review with manager; set the week's activity and meeting targets; refresh target-account list.
- **Tue–Thu:** Peak outbound days — the bulk of calls, emails, and discovery calls. Protect the morning power hour ruthlessly.
- **Friday:** Follow-ups, admin, CRM clean-up, and a personal retro: which messages/opening lines converted, which stage leaked, what to change next week.
- **Ongoing:** Weekly 1:1 with the manager (coaching, call reviews), team stand-ups, and product/competitor learning. Top reps treat every lost deal as a data point and adjust the system.

The pattern to internalise: sales at this level is a **volume-and-consistency game run as a measurable process** — set daily activity numbers derived from your funnel math (§10), execute them regardless of mood, log everything, and improve the weakest conversion step each week. That is precisely a systematic-trading mentality applied to human conversations, and it is why your background can make you unusually good at this.

Key takeaways: A good SDR/BDE day = morning prospecting power hour, discovery calls, a second outreach/follow-up block, and end-of-day CRM hygiene. The week = plan Monday, grind Tue–Thu, clean up + retro Friday. Run it as a measured, repeatable system; improve the weakest stage each week.

18. Q&A bank (40 questions)

A mix of concept checks and interview questions with model answers. For interviews, keep answers structured and use a specific example — your F&O/analytical background is a differentiator when framed well.

18.1 Concept questions

Q1. In one line, what is sales?

A: Helping a specific, identified prospect move from a problem to your solution and securing a commitment — the transfer of belief that you solve their problem better than the alternatives, including doing nothing.

Q2. How is business development different from sales?

A: Sales converts identified prospects through a defined process; BD creates new paths to revenue — new markets, segments, partners, channels — often before a repeatable process exists. In small Indian firms "BD" usually just means front-line sales; confirm from the JD.

Q3. Distinguish sales from marketing.

A: Marketing is one-to-many demand creation (awareness, leads, brand at scale); sales is one-to-one demand capture and conversion of individual prospects into paying customers. Marketing generates leads and hands them to sales to close.

Q4. What does an SDR do, and how is it different from an AE?

A: An SDR (Sales Development Rep) prospects and qualifies to create opportunities — they open deals but don't close. An AE (Account Executive) takes qualified opportunities and closes them into paying customers, carrying a revenue quota.

Q5. What's the difference between a funnel and a pipeline?

A: The funnel is a model of average conversion across stages (a rear-view aggregate). The pipeline is your live list of real, named deals, each with a value, a stage-probability, and a close date — your open book. You manage and forecast the pipeline; you analyse the funnel.

Q6. Why is pipeline more useful day-to-day than funnel?

A: You can't close a "funnel" — you close specific deals. The pipeline tells you which named deals exist, worth how much, likely to close when, so you can forecast (weighted pipeline = Σ deal value $\times$ stage probability) and act. The funnel only tells you historical averages.

Q7. Define MQL and SQL.

A: MQL (Marketing Qualified Lead) = a lead marketing judges interested/fit enough to pass to sales. SQL (Sales Qualified Lead) = a lead sales has verified for real need, fit, and intent and will actively pursue.

Q8. Walk me through the buyer's journey.

A: Awareness (buyer senses a problem but hasn't defined it — you educate), Consideration (they compare options — you diagnose and show fit), Decision (they justify and de-risk the choice — you provide ROI, proof, references). Match your message to the stage; the invisible rival throughout is "do nothing."

Q9. Name the stages of the end-to-end sales cycle.

A: Prospect → Qualify → Discover → Present/Demo → Handle objections → Close → Onboard → Expand. Qualifying (disqualifying fast) is the discipline that protects your time; the sale continues after "closed won" into onboarding and expansion.

Q10. What is BANT?

A: A qualification checklist — Budget (can they pay?), Authority (am I talking to the decision-maker?), Need (is there a real, painful problem?), Timing (is there a timeframe to act?). A beginner's workhorse for deciding whether a lead is worth pursuing.

Q11. B2B vs B2C selling — key differences?

A: B2B = sell to an organisation and its buying committee; long cycle, high ticket, driven by rational ROI/risk. B2C = sell to one individual; fast, lower ticket, emotion/convenience-driven. The B2B trap is treating it like B2C and forgetting the committee.

Q12. What is B2B2C? Give a fintech example.

A: Selling through a business partner to reach end-consumers. Example: a lender embedding Buy-Now-Pay-Later inside a retailer's checkout — the lender sells to the retailer, but consumers use the credit.

Q13. Explain consultative vs transactional selling.

A: Transactional = fast, price/convenience-led, minimal advising — good for simple cheap products. Consultative = ask deep questions, diagnose the real need, recommend a fit — good when the buyer is unsure. The rule: diagnose before you prescribe.

Q14. What is value selling?

A: Quantifying business impact in the buyer's own terms — rupees saved or earned, risk reduced — and selling that outcome and ROI rather than features. Best for high-ticket, competitive, ROI-driven deals.

Q15. Inbound vs outbound?

A: Inbound = the prospect contacts you first (warmer, but still qualify hard). Outbound = you contact them cold (harder, higher rejection, but you choose exactly whom to target). Mastering outbound makes you durably valuable because you can create pipeline on demand.

Q16. What is an ICP and why does it matter?

A: Ideal Customer Profile — a precise description of the customers you serve best (fastest close, most value, longest retention). It's your targeting filter; selling outside ICP is the top way sellers waste months on doomed deals.

Q17. What is a value proposition?

A: A crisp statement of the outcome you deliver: for [ICP] who [have this problem], we provide [this], delivering [quantified outcome], unlike [alternatives]. It's about the buyer's outcome, not your features.

Q18. Define positioning.

A: The place your product occupies in the buyer's mind relative to alternatives — the category you claim and why you're the right choice within it (e.g., "the security-first payments API for regulated fintechs" vs "the cheapest gateway").

Q19. Explain the three sales motions.

A: Self-serve/PLG (customer signs up and pays online, product sells itself; low ticket), inside sales (reps sell remotely by phone/video; mid ticket), field sales (in-person, high-touch, strategic; high ticket). Motion scales with deal size; freshers usually start in inside sales/SDR.

Q20. What is RevOps?

A: Revenue Operations — the team that builds and runs the systems the revenue engine depends on: CRM, data, reporting, forecasting, commissions, process design. If sales is the trading desk, RevOps is its tech-and-risk infrastructure — a strong fit for an analytical/CS profile.

Q21. Define OTE, quota, and accelerator.

A: OTE (On-Target Earnings) = base + variable if you hit 100% of target. Quota = the target you must hit to earn full variable. Accelerator = a higher commission rate on revenue booked above 100% of quota — where top reps make outsized money.

Q22. What does CTC include, and why be careful with it?

A: CTC (Cost To Company) is the total annual cost of employing you — it blends fixed salary, non-guaranteed variable, employer PF/gratuity, benefits, and sometimes notional ESOP value. Only the fixed part is guaranteed, so headline CTC overstates take-home; always decompose it.

Q23. What is speed-to-lead and why does it matter?

A: How fast sales follows up an inbound lead. Responding in ~5 minutes vs 30+ can multiply conversion because the buyer's intent is highest right after they reach out. It's a common sales–marketing SLA metric.

Q24. What's a healthy pipeline coverage ratio and why above 1x?

A: Often about 3x–4x quota — you need roughly ₹3–4 of open pipeline for every ₹1 of target because most deals slip or die. Low coverage today is a leading indicator of a missed quota next quarter.

Q25. What is Net Revenue Retention (NRR)?

A: Whether an existing customer base's spend grew, held, or shrank over a period (upsell/cross-sell minus churn/downgrade). It's the core metric for AM/CSM and a sign of a healthy business — existing customers are the cheapest revenue.

18.2 Interview questions**Q26. "You have no sales experience — why should we hire you?"**

A: "I bring the parts of sales most reps lack: disciplined, data-driven process. On a derivatives desk I executed a repeatable system under rejection and uncertainty every day without letting emotion drive decisions — that's exactly what running a pipeline and handling rejection require. I can do funnel math backwards from a revenue target to a daily activity number, keep flawless CRM hygiene, and diagnose which conversion stage is leaking. The human layer — listening, discovery — I'm coachable on and already practising. I'm not starting at zero; I'm starting with an unusual edge on the analytical half."

Q27. "Sell me this pen."

A: Don't pitch features. Discover first: "Before I do — when did you last use a pen, and for what? What matters to you in one — reliability, how it feels, looking professional in a meeting?" Then sell to what they said: "You mentioned signing contracts in front of clients — this one's weighted to feel premium and never skips, so you look sharp at the moment that matters." The point you're demonstrating: diagnose before you prescribe.

Q28. "How do you handle rejection?"

A: "I treat it as expected data, not a verdict on me. If cold outreach converts at ~8%, then ~92% of contacts saying no is the system working normally, not failure — each no moves me through a known conversion rate toward the next yes. My trading background trained exactly this: you don't rage at a losing trade in a positive-expectancy system; you take the next signal and keep the process consistent."

Q29. "Walk me through how you'd research and approach a cold prospect."

A: "First, confirm they fit our ICP. Then research the company (recent funding, growth, tech stack, hiring) and the person (role, LinkedIn, likely pain). I craft a short, personalised opener tied to a specific observation and a likely problem we solve — not a feature dump. I lead with their world, ask for a short discovery call, and follow up 4–5 times across channels, because most replies come after the first touch. Everything logged in the CRM."

Q30. "What would you do in your first 30/60/90 days?"

A: "First 30: learn the product, ICP, competitors, and the sales process cold; shadow calls; master the CRM. Days 30–60: run outreach at target activity, do lots of discovery, get coaching on my calls, start booking meetings. Days 60–90: hit ramped targets, identify which conversion stage I'm weakest at and drill it, and start contributing feedback to marketing on lead quality. Throughout: consistency over heroics."

Q31. "A prospect says 'your product is too expensive.' What do you do?"

A: "First understand, not defend: 'Too expensive compared to what — another vendor, or versus doing nothing?' Often it's a value gap, not a price problem. I'd re-anchor on the quantified outcome from discovery — e.g., 'it's ₹1 lakh/year, but it saves ~₹4 lakh in finance-team hours and penalty risk' — so we compare price to value, not price to zero. If it's a genuine budget constraint, I explore scope, phasing, or terms. I never just discount reflexively; that trains the buyer to distrust the price."

Q32. "Why sales, coming from finance/trading?"

A: "Two honest reasons. One, I like being close to where value is created and measured — sales is the most direct line between effort and outcome, and I'm comfortable being judged on a number. Two, I realised my edge is turning analytical rigour into human results: I enjoy understanding a counterparty's real problem and building a case that helps them decide. Sales lets me use both the quant discipline and the people side, and the ceiling — into RevOps, KAM, or leadership — is high."

Q33. "How would you prioritise your day with 200 leads and limited time?"

A: "Score them by ICP fit and intent signals — an inbound demo request from an on-ICP company outranks a cold, off-ICP name. I'd hit the highest fit-plus-intent leads first and fast (speed-to-lead), disqualify obvious poor fits quickly to protect my time, and batch the rest into my outreach blocks. It's the same logic as sizing positions by expected value: put the most effort where the expected return is highest."

Q34. "What makes a good discovery call?"

A: "The buyer talks ~60–70% of the time. I ask open, layered questions from surface pain to business impact to cost of inaction, and I quantify (hours, rupees, risk). I uncover the buying process and who else must sign off. I resist pitching until I genuinely understand the problem — ideally I can restate their problem better than they can. I confirm a clear next step before ending."

Q35. "How do you know if a deal is qualified or a waste of time?"

A: "I check for real, painful need; budget or a path to it; access to the decision-maker(s); and a genuine timeframe (BANT). If there's no compelling event, no budget, or I can't reach anyone with authority, I disqualify or park it. Disqualifying fast is a skill — chasing bad-fit deals is the sales version of averaging down on a loser."

Q36. "Tell me about a time you were persistent / handled a setback." (behavioural)

A: Use STAR (Situation, Task, Action, Result). Pick a real story — e.g., a long stretch on the desk where a strategy underperformed, you stuck to the disciplined process rather than deviating emotionally, kept refining based on data, and it paid off. Tie it explicitly to sales: "That's the same resilience and consistency a pipeline demands."

Q37. "How would you sell our fintech product to an SME finance head?"

A: "I'd start with their world, not our features: understand their current workflow and where it hurts — say, a 6-day month-end and manual GST reconciliation. Quantify the pain in hours and rupees and penalty risk. Then map our product to that specific pain, show a peer's story and an ROI model, and de-risk with a short pilot and security docs for their IT. Finally, identify the buying committee — CFO, IT — and make sure each is comfortable before asking for the signature."

Q38. "What's the difference between a feature and a benefit — and which do you sell?"

A: A feature is what the product *is/does* ('auto-matches GST invoices'); a benefit is what that *means for the buyer* ('you file in hours not days, with fewer penalties'). You sell benefits — ideally quantified into the buyer's outcome — because buyers care about their result, not your mechanics. Features prove the benefit is real."

Q39. "How do you keep your pipeline forecast honest?"

A: "Rigorous CRM hygiene: update every deal's stage, next step, and close date after each interaction; move dead deals to closed-lost instead of leaving them 'open'; and never inflate close dates to look good. I forecast with weighted pipeline (deal value × stage probability) and watch coverage vs quota. An honest small pipeline beats a fantasy large one — inflated forecasts blow up on the manager and on me."

Q40. "What would you do if you were far behind quota mid-quarter?"

A: "Diagnose before I panic — which stage is leaking? If it's top-of-funnel, I ramp outreach and tighten targeting to ICP. If discovery-to-opportunity is weak, I fix my qualification and questioning with my manager. If proposals aren't closing, I revisit value framing and objection handling. I'd also prioritise the highest-EV open deals, disqualify the dead ones to free time, and ask my manager to coach a few live deals. Then execute the raised activity numbers consistently — the math, run daily, is what recovers a quarter."

19. Glossary of every acronym

Term	Meaning
ACV	Annual Contract Value — yearly revenue from one contract
AE	Account Executive — the closer who carries a revenue quota
AM	Account Manager — renews and grows existing accounts
AMC	Asset Management Company — runs mutual funds
BANT	Budget, Authority, Need, Timing — a qualification checklist
BD	Business Development — creating new paths to revenue
BDE	Business Development Executive — usually a closing/inside-sales role in India
BDR	Business Development Representative — outbound prospector
BFSI	Banking, Financial Services & Insurance
CAC	Customer Acquisition Cost — cost to acquire one customer
CRM	Customer Relationship Management system (e.g., Salesforce, HubSpot, Zoho)
CRO	Chief Revenue Officer — owns the whole revenue engine
CS / CSM	Customer Success / Customer Success Manager — drives adoption & retention
CTC	Cost To Company — total annual cost of employing you (fixed + variable + benefits)
D2C	Direct-to-Consumer — brands selling straight to end-consumers
F&O	Futures & Options — derivatives
GTM	Go-To-Market — the plan for how a company sells a product
ICP	Ideal Customer Profile — the customer you serve best
IRDAI	Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India
JD	Job Description
KAM	Key Account Manager — owns the largest strategic accounts
LPA	Lakh Per Annum — ₹1 lakh = ₹1,00,000
MEDDIC	An advanced qualification framework (Metrics, Economic buyer, Decision criteria, Decision process, Identify pain, Champion)
MQL	Marketing Qualified Lead
NISM	National Institute of Securities Markets — SEBI-linked certification body
NPS	Net Promoter Score — a customer-loyalty measure
NRR	Net Revenue Retention — growth in existing-customer revenue
OTE	On-Target Earnings — base + variable at 100% of quota
PF	Provident Fund — a retirement contribution included in CTC
PLG	Product-Led Growth — the product drives self-serve acquisition

Term	Meaning
PMS	Portfolio Management Service
RBI	Reserve Bank of India
RevOps	Revenue Operations — builds the systems/data behind the revenue engine
RM	Relationship Manager — sales role common in BFSI
ROI	Return on Investment
SaaS	Software-as-a-Service — software sold on subscription
SDR	Sales Development Representative — prospector who qualifies leads
SEBI	Securities and Exchange Board of India
SLA	Service Level Agreement — a mutual promise (e.g., lead volume + follow-up speed)
SME	Small and Medium Enterprise
SPIN	Situation, Problem, Implication, Need-payoff — a discovery-questioning framework
SQL	Sales Qualified Lead
STAR	Situation, Task, Action, Result — structure for behavioural answers

Final word: This guide is the map. You now know what sales and BD are, the roles ladder, B2B/B2C, selling styles, the buyer's journey, funnel vs pipeline (with the math), the eight-stage cycle, the core human skills, GTM, and how to read an Indian offer. The next guides drill into each stage — prospecting, discovery, demos, objection handling, negotiation, and closing. Run sales like a positive-expectancy system: disciplined process, honest pipeline, relentless consistency, zero mis-selling. Your analytical edge plus the human layer is a rare and hireable combination.